

Winter sports

Sports have taken place on snow and ice for centuries. Today, most winter sports are variations of skiing, sledding, or ice skating. These sports have their own multi-sport tournament, the Winter Olympic Games, which takes place every four years.

ALPINE SKIING

Alpine skiing is an exhilarating sport of speed and skill. There are five types of alpine ski competition. Two of the disciplines – downhill and Super-G – focus on speed. Slalom and giant slalom are technical events, in which a competitor's skill will win the day. The fifth event, called combined (a mix of downhill and slalom), tests both speed and technique.

TOP ALPINE SKIERS

○ KJETIL ANDRE AAMODT (NORWAY)

The only alpine skier to win eight Olympic medals, four of them gold – in Super-G (1992, 2002, 2006) and combined (2002).

○ JANICA KOSTELIC (CROATIA)

The only woman in history to win four Winter Olympic golds – three in 2002 and one in 2006.

○ ALBERTO TOMBA (ITALY)

The dominant technical skier of the late 1980s and early 1990s.



ALTERNATIVE SKIING METHODS

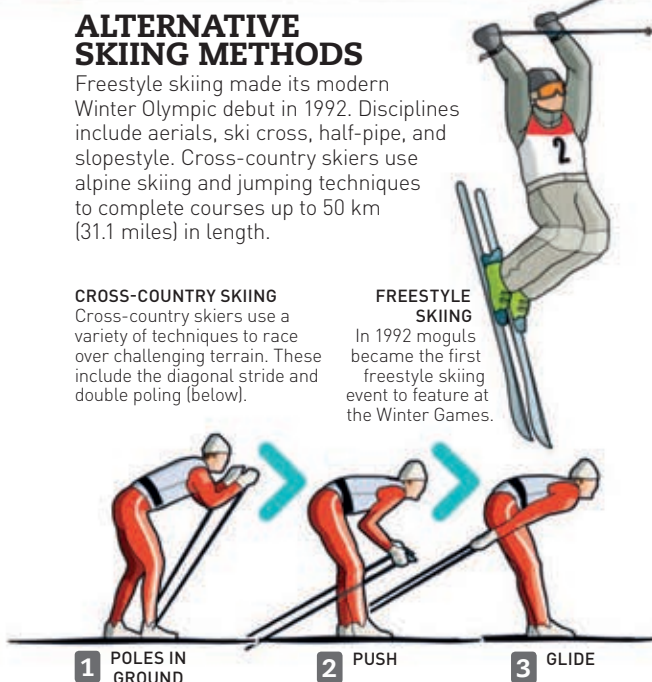
Freestyle skiing made its modern Winter Olympic debut in 1992. Disciplines include aerials, ski cross, half-pipe, and slopestyle. Cross-country skiers use alpine skiing and jumping techniques to complete courses up to 50 km (31.1 miles) in length.

CROSS-COUNTRY SKIING

Cross-country skiers use a variety of techniques to race over challenging terrain. These include the diagonal stride and double poling (below).

FREESTYLE SKIING

In 1992 moguls became the first freestyle skiing event to feature at the Winter Games.



SNOWBOARDING

Developed in the USA in the 1960s, snowboarding has enjoyed an explosion in popularity in recent years. Inspired by skateboarding, skiing, and surfing, snowboarders descend a slope while standing on a ski-like board attached to their feet.

EQUIPMENT

Snowboarders need a board, boots, some bindings to attach the boots to the board, a pair of goggles, and a helmet.



THE WORD "SLALOM" COMES FROM THE NORWEGIAN WORD "SLALAM", MEANING "GENTLE SLOPE"

EQUIPMENT

The standard equipment for alpine skiing includes skis (which have different shapes for different disciplines), poles, a helmet, goggles, boots, and bindings, which attach the boot to the ski.



DIFFERENT COURSES

Every alpine-ski discipline tests different skills, so the courses for each are set out differently. A downhill course has the fewest gates (poles), whereas a slalom has many poles through which the skier must pass.

